SIDEBAR 2.2

How to Know Whether You Have an Original Article Idea

You should be able to answer "yes" to at least the majority of the following 10 questions:

1. Is this topic so new and original that you can't find any books written on the subject?
2. Will your topic appeal to the special-interest group who read the magazine you are interested in writing for? Or is there a magazine that focuses on what you are interested in writing about?
3. Does this topic deal with fundamental life issues such as death, love, sickness, money, careers, health—issues that affect millions of people?
4. Do you have a strong, central unifying theme?
5. Can you state your theme in one sentence using an action verb?
6. Does your angle allow you to offer intelligent insight—as opposed to saying something that's obvious, that's commonsense or that readers have read about many times?
7. Are there elements of drama or conflict to attract and sustain the reader?
8. Will your topic generate several colorful and compelling anecdotes from your sources? Can you find human-interest stories about it?
9. Does your theme question or contradict what most people think or assume? The best articles question the conventional wisdom about a subject.
10. Do you have access to the sources you need to write this article? These sources should be participants, keen observers or experts on the topic you are writing about.

steady flow of ideas has to read continually, including publications that few others read. Ideas may come from unexpected sources: professional quarterlies, association newsletters, academic journals, annual reports and almanacs. While they seem boring, such sources often contain the most original thinking and latest developments long before they reach the general public. Here are more specific items to read or places to look as you dig for ideas for your feature articles.